missions.[11] More famously, Admiral Zheng He, in the early fifteenth century, led seven expeditions into the Indian Ocean region including to the Malabar coast and Bengal.[12] Some contemporary Chinese interpretations portray Zheng He's voyages as a benevolent exercise in which a hegemonic navy controlled piracy, managed local conflicts from Southeast Asia through South Asia to the Gulf and east coast of Africa, and laid the basis for a cosmopolitan trading environment which worked to everyone's benefit. In other words, China delivered what economists call a 'public good'. More accurately, though, Zheng He was sent to enlarge tributary relations, to expand China's imperial and private trade, and bring home exotica of various kinds. Often enough, his navy intervened in local affairs, siding with one ruler against a rival, and using the threat if not actual use of force to settle the matter – including in parts of Kerala and Bengal. This was Chinese imperialism, plain and simple. As Sen notes, 'many of the features of the Zheng He expeditions were similar to the activities of the European colonial powers subsequently'.[13]

By the early fifteenth century, interactions between India and China had declined. This was in part due to the Song dynasty's decision, at the height of its maritime imperialism, to discourage the voyages of Zheng He and other Chinese naval expeditions. Tribute to China continued sporadically, mostly from the South China Sea area and from parts of India and Sri Lanka through intermediaries in Southeast Asia. With the disappearance of Chinese maritime control, the Portuguese, the Dutch, and the British in turn adopted and adapted Zheng Ho's network and maritime order. Chinese imperialism was replaced by European imperialism.

From the fourth to the end of the ninth century, with the spread of Buddhism, China – or at least some Chinese – had looked to India as a spiritual centre. From about the eleventh to the early fifteenth century, Chinese reverence for India was replaced by Indian reverence for China in the form of tributes from various Indian kingdoms. The next four hundred years saw the Portuguese, Dutch, and British insert themselves into the relationship. India and China no longer dealt with each other in the direct if limited sense that had marked the period from the fourth to the fifteenth